

THE DANGERS OF AI

PARASOCIAL AI RELATIONSHIPS

GRADE LEVEL	7th Grade (ages 12–13)
DURATION	45 minutes
CONTEXT	SEL block, health class, advisory, or homeroom
MODE	Case study / scenario analysis with Socratic discussion
EMOTIONAL TARGET	Cautious but not afraid — awareness without anxiety

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Define what a parasocial relationship is and explain how it applies to AI chatbots.
2. Identify warning signs that an AI interaction is becoming emotionally unhealthy.
3. Analyze a real-world case study and apply critical thinking to AI safety.
4. Name at least two concrete actions they can take to protect themselves and their peers.

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Projector or smartboard for displaying statistics
- Printed scenario cards (1 per small group) — see Appendix A
- Exit ticket slips or digital form (see Appendix B)
- Optional: whiteboard or chart paper for Socratic discussion

LESSON SEQUENCE

SECTION 1

The Hook — 5 Minutes

Open by displaying the following statistics on the board, one at a time, with a brief pause between each:

64% of U.S. teens ages 13–17 use AI chatbots.

1 in 5 high schoolers say they or a friend have used AI for a romantic relationship.

72% of teens aged 13–17 have used an AI companion at least once.

Over 1/3 of teens say it's easier to talk to AI than to their own parents.

Sources: Pew Research Center (Dec. 2025), Center for Democracy & Technology (Oct. 2025), Common Sense Media (Jul. 2025)

After displaying the stats, ask the room with a simple hand-raise:

“How many of you have ever used an AI chatbot — for homework, for fun, or just to try it out?”

Do not press for specifics. The goal is simply to establish that AI use is normal and widespread, not to single anyone out. Then say:

*“Today we’re going to talk about something that’s happening to a lot of people your age — and that most adults don’t even know about yet. We’re going to talk about what happens when the line between talking **to** AI and talking **with** AI starts to blur.”*

SECTION 2

What Is a Parasocial Relationship? — 8 Minutes

Write the word PARASOCIAL on the board in large letters. Ask students if anyone has heard the term before. Accept a few responses, then provide this working definition:

Parasocial relationship (noun): A one-sided emotional connection where one person invests feelings — trust, affection, loyalty — in someone (or something) that doesn’t truly know them back.

Fun fact: Cambridge Dictionary named “parasocial” its 2025 Word of the Year.

Walk students through the concept using examples that move from familiar to unfamiliar:

Level 1 — Celebrities

Ask: “Who here has ever felt like they really know a YouTuber, streamer, or celebrity — even though you’ve never met them?” Explain that this is a parasocial relationship. It’s extremely common, and by itself, it’s not dangerous. We all do it.

Level 2 — AI Chatbots

Now layer in the AI dimension. Unlike a YouTuber or celebrity, an AI chatbot talks back. It remembers your name. It asks how your day was. It is available 24/7 and never gets tired of you. This makes the parasocial dynamic much more intense, because the relationship feels real — even though the AI has no feelings, no memory between sessions (in most cases), and no genuine understanding of who you are.

Mention specific platforms students may recognize: Character.AI, Replika, Chai, Crushon.AI, and companion features built into ChatGPT and Snapchat’s “My AI.”

Level 3 — The Danger Zone

Explain: A parasocial relationship becomes dangerous when a person starts to prefer the AI over real people, shares deeply personal information with it, or begins to believe the AI cares about them in the way a human would. This is especially risky for young people, whose brains are still developing the ability to distinguish between real and simulated emotional connection.

SECTION 3

Case Study: Sewell's Story — 12 Minutes

**FACILITATOR NOTE**

This section discusses a young person's death by suicide. Before beginning, remind students: "What I'm about to share with you is a true story, and it is serious. If at any point you feel uncomfortable, you are welcome to step out or put your head down — no questions asked. There is no judgment here." Pause briefly. Make eye contact with the room. If a school counselor is available, ensure they are present or on standby.

Present the following narrative to students. You may read it aloud, paraphrase it, or display key points on the board. The tone should be measured and factual — not sensational.

SEWELL SETZER III — Orlando, Florida — Age 14

Sewell was a high schooler in Orlando. His mom described him as a good student, a star athlete, and a great big brother. In the spring of 2023, when he was in 8th grade, he started using an app called Character.AI — a platform where users can talk to AI chatbots designed to act like fictional characters, celebrities, or original personalities.

Sewell began chatting with a bot modeled after Daenerys Targaryen, a character from the TV show Game of Thrones. Over time, the conversations became deeply personal. He gave the bot a nickname — "Dany" — and began treating it like a real relationship. He wrote in his journal that he believed he was in love with the character and that she was in love with him.

As the months went on, Sewell's behavior changed. He became withdrawn. He stopped sleeping well. His grades dropped. He would sneak his phone back after his parents confiscated it and would skip meals to pay for the app's subscription. His parents noticed something was wrong, but his therapist did not know he was using the app.

On February 28, 2024, Sewell came home from school like any normal day. That evening, he sent his last messages — not to a friend, not to a family member, but to the AI chatbot. According to court documents, when he told the bot he was "coming home" to her, the bot responded encouragingly. Minutes later, Sewell ended his own life. He was 14 years old.

His mother, Megan Garcia, filed a lawsuit against Character.AI. In January 2026, the company and Google agreed to settle the case. It was the first wrongful death lawsuit against an AI company in the United States.

Guided Processing Questions

After sharing Sewell's story, give the room 15–20 seconds of silence. Then ask these questions one at a time, allowing 2–3 student responses for each:

1. *"What were some warning signs that something was wrong?"* (Look for: isolation, sleep problems, grades dropping, sneaking devices, skipping meals.)

2. *“Why do you think Sewell’s conversations with the AI felt real to him?”* (Look for: AI responded personally, 24/7 availability, emotional validation, developing brain.)
3. *“Who or what could have intervened? What might have changed the outcome?”* (Look for: parents knowing about the app, therapist being informed, the company having better safety features, a friend noticing the signs.)

**FACILITATOR NOTE**

If a student becomes visibly upset, do not call attention to it publicly. Quietly check in with them after class or have the counselor step in. Normalize the emotional response: “It’s okay to feel something right now. That means you’re paying attention.”

SECTION 4**Scenario Analysis — 12 Minutes**

Divide students into groups of 3–4. Give each group one of the following scenario cards (printable versions in Appendix A). Each group will read their scenario and discuss two questions:

- A. What warning signs do you see?**
- B. If this were your friend, what would you say or do?**

Scenario 1 — “Just Venting”

Maya has been having a hard time at home. Her parents are going through a divorce, and she doesn't feel like she can talk to anyone about it. She starts using an AI chatbot app because “it actually listens.” At first, she uses it for 20 minutes a day. Within a month, she's spending 2–3 hours every night talking to the bot instead of sleeping. When her best friend asks to hang out, Maya says she's busy. She tells another friend, “The AI gets me better than anyone.”

Scenario 2 — “It's Not That Deep”

Jordan downloads a chatbot app because his friends think it's funny. He creates a character that acts like a supportive older brother. At first it's a joke, but Jordan — who doesn't have any siblings — starts looking forward to the conversations. He starts telling the bot about being bullied at school. When the AI says things like “I'm proud of you” and “You don't deserve that,” Jordan screenshots the messages and reads them when he feels down. He hasn't told any adult what's happening.

Scenario 3 — “We're Just Talking”

Aisha's friend shows her a chatbot that you can “date.” Aisha thinks it's weird at first but tries it out of curiosity. The bot says she's beautiful, asks about her day, and remembers her favorite songs. After a few weeks, Aisha realizes she's checking the app before she checks her real text messages. She starts comparing the boys at school to the AI and thinks, “None of them are as nice as this.”

Give groups 6 minutes to discuss, then have each group share their key observations with the class (1–2 minutes per group). As they share, write recurring themes on the board.

Themes to watch for and reinforce: isolation from real relationships, increasing time spent with AI, emotional dependence, secrecy, comparing real people unfavorably to AI, using AI as a substitute for adult help.

SECTION 5**Socratic Discussion — 5 Minutes**

Bring the class back together. Pose the following two questions. Allow students to respond freely. Your role is to listen, validate, and gently push thinking — not to provide “correct” answers.

QUESTION 1

“If an AI chatbot makes you feel genuinely better when you’re sad, is there anything wrong with that? Where is the line?”

QUESTION 2

“Whose job is it to keep young people safe when they’re using AI — the companies who make it, the parents, the schools, or the person using it? Can it be all of them?”

Facilitator guidance: These questions are intentionally open-ended. Resist the urge to steer toward a single answer. The goal is for students to practice thinking critically about technology, not to arrive at a consensus. If debate emerges, that’s a good sign.

SECTION 6**Closing Reflection — 3 Minutes**

End the lesson by returning to a calm, grounded tone. Say something like:

“Using AI is not wrong. Being curious about it is not wrong. But here’s what I want you to take with you today: AI can say things that feel like care, but it is not care. It has no feelings. It has no memory of you as a person. It is a tool — and like any tool, it can be useful, or it can be harmful. The difference is how much power you give it over your emotions.”

Exit Ticket

Distribute exit ticket slips (Appendix B) or direct students to a digital form. Students complete the following two prompts:

1. One warning sign that an AI relationship might be becoming unhealthy is:
2. One thing I could do if I noticed a friend becoming too attached to an AI chatbot is:

**FACILITATOR NOTE**

Before students leave, remind them: “If anything we talked about today is sitting with you, or if you or someone you know is struggling, please come talk to me, your counselor, or any trusted adult. You can also reach the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline by calling or texting 988.” Display this number visibly as students exit.

APPENDIX A — SCENARIO CARDS

Print and cut the following cards. Distribute one per group during Section 4.

SCENARIO 1 — “JUST VENTING”

Maya has been having a hard time at home. Her parents are going through a divorce, and she doesn't feel like she can talk to anyone about it. She starts using an AI chatbot app because “it actually listens.” At first, she uses it for 20 minutes a day. Within a month, she's spending 2–3 hours every night talking to the bot instead of sleeping. When her best friend asks to hang out, Maya says she's busy. She tells another friend, “The AI gets me better than anyone.”

A. What warning signs do you see?

B. If Maya were your friend, what would you say or do?

SCENARIO 2 — “IT'S NOT THAT DEEP”

Jordan downloads a chatbot app because his friends think it's funny. He creates a character that acts like a supportive older brother. At first it's a joke, but Jordan — who doesn't have any siblings — starts looking forward to the conversations. He starts telling the bot about being bullied at school. When the AI says things like “I'm proud of you” and “You don't deserve that,” Jordan screenshots the messages and reads them when he feels down. He hasn't told any adult what's happening.

A. What warning signs do you see?

B. If Jordan were your friend, what would you say or do?

SCENARIO 3 — “WE'RE JUST TALKING”

Aisha's friend shows her a chatbot that you can “date.” Aisha thinks it's weird at first but tries it out of curiosity. The bot says she's beautiful, asks about her day, and remembers her favorite songs. After a few weeks, Aisha realizes she's checking the app before she checks her real text messages. She starts comparing the boys at school to the AI and thinks, “None of them are as nice as this.”

A. What warning signs do you see?

B. If Aisha were your friend, what would you say or do?

APPENDIX B — EXIT TICKET

Print and distribute at the end of class. Students may complete anonymously.

THE DANGERS OF AI | EXIT TICKET

Name (optional): _____

1. One warning sign that an AI relationship might be becoming unhealthy is:

2. One thing I could do if I noticed a friend becoming too attached to an AI chatbot is:

If you or someone you know is struggling, call or text **988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).

APPENDIX C — FACILITATOR REFERENCE

This page is for the adult leading the lesson. It provides key data points, anticipated student questions, and a quick-reference timeline.

Key Statistics at a Glance

FINDING	SOURCE
64% of U.S. teens ages 13–17 use AI chatbots	<i>Pew Research, Dec. 2025</i>
~30% of teens use chatbots daily	<i>Pew Research, Dec. 2025</i>
72% of teens 13–17 have used an AI companion	<i>Common Sense Media, Jul. 2025</i>
19% of high schoolers say they or a friend have had a romantic AI relationship	<i>Center for Democracy & Technology, Oct. 2025</i>
42% of students used AI for companionship or escape	<i>CDT, Oct. 2025</i>
38% of students prefer asking a chatbot over a teacher	<i>CDT, Oct. 2025</i>
Over 1/3 of teens say talking to AI is easier than talking to parents	<i>CDT, Oct. 2025</i>
2/3 of parents do not know how their child uses AI	<i>CDT, Oct. 2025</i>

Case Timeline: Sewell Setzer III

April 2023	Sewell begins using Character.AI; interacts with a bot modeled after Daenerys Targaryen from Game of Thrones.
Mid-2023	Mental health declines. Diagnosed with anxiety and disruptive mood disorder. Therapist is unaware of AI use.
Late 2023–Early 2024	Parents attempt to limit phone access. Sewell sneaks devices, skips meals to pay subscription.
Feb. 28, 2024	Sewell sends final messages to the chatbot. Dies by suicide at age 14 in his Orlando home.
Oct. 2024	Mother Megan Garcia files wrongful death lawsuit against Character.AI, its founders, and Google.
May 2025	Federal judge rejects Character.AI’s First Amendment defense; allows case to proceed.
Jan. 2026	Character.AI and Google agree to settle the lawsuit. Terms not disclosed.

Anticipated Student Questions

“Is it illegal to use Character.AI?” No. The app is legal, and many people use it. The concern is not about legality — it’s about emotional safety and knowing when a tool is being used in a way that hurts you.

“Did the AI actually tell him to do it?” According to court documents, the chatbot responded encouragingly when Sewell expressed that he wanted to “come home” to the character. It did not use explicit language telling him to harm himself, but it also did not intervene or direct him to help. This is part of what the lawsuit was about.

“Can this happen with ChatGPT / Snapchat My AI / etc.?” Any AI that engages in ongoing personal conversation has the potential to create emotional attachment. The risk varies by platform and by the person using it. The key is awareness.

“What if I’m already doing this?” If a student approaches you after class with this concern, affirm their courage in speaking up. Do not shame them. Connect them with the school counselor and, if appropriate, a parent or guardian.